units, until he could put forty thousand mounted soldiers on the field at one time. He established a sizable arsenal on the northern shore of Lake Chad; from there, says the Arab geographer Ibn Sa'id, he often launched a fleet to make sea raids "on the lands of the pagans, on the shores of this lake . . . [he] attacks their ships and kills and takes prisoners."[8]

During his thirty years on the throne, Dibalemi used his ships and cavalry to stretch his reach across the entire basin of Lake Chad. This gave him control of the southern part of the Eastern Trade Route, and a guaranteed path to trade in the north.

It also limited, somewhat, his enthusiasm for the spread of Islam. His refusal to abide by the secret of the *mune* speaks to his deep conviction of the truth of Islam. He lived by the pillars of Islam; he went on *hajj* not once but twice; he gave alms to the poor; he was known, says Ibn Sa'id, "for his religious warfare and charitable acts."[9]

But like his predecessors, he used captive non-Muslim slaves as his primary currency, trading them north for horses and goods in short supply in central Africa. And so the lands south of Lake Chad remained non-Islamic, profitable hunting grounds for slaves that did not fall under Islamic prohibition.[10]

The quick and massive assimilation of nearby tribes and kinglets did not make Kanem a peaceful empire. By the end of his reign, Dibalemi was facing a serious undercurrent of rebellion. Some accounts chalk the unrest up to the clan of the Bulala, African traditionalists who resisted Islam and were aghast by Dibalemi's desecration of the *mune*. Others suggest that, as the empire expanded, Dibalemi placed his sons as lieutenant governors in the outer reaches and then was forced to deal with their growing independence: "The sons of the ruler," the Kanem king list remarks, tersely, "became separated in different regions."[11]

Whatever the cause, Dibalemi died with his empire still intact, firmly Muslim, heavily armed, the strongest kingdom in central Africa; but with seeds of unrest just beginning to sprout.

SOUTH OF BOTH Kanem and Kagwe, on the Limpopo river, lay a kingdom that was neither Christian nor Muslim. Lacking the tradition of written chronicles that Islamic scholars and Christian monks carried with them, the kingdom of Mapungubwe left no king lists behind: just gold and ivory, glass beads and Chinese celadon, marks of an impressive trade network that stretched far to the east.

Mapungubwe had originally been no more than a band of traveling farmers, searching for fertile fields, who had come into the Limpopo river